Low-Complexity Digital Scams: An OSINT Investigative Approach and Verification Failures in "Money Mule" MEI Accounts

By André Almeida

Disclaimer: *This paper documents an investigation based on a real-world case, developed exclusively for educational purposes. To preserve the right to privacy and maintain our commitment to ethical OSINT practices, all names, documents, addresses, and identifiers cited have been altered or anonymized.*

The Case and The Scheme

Psychological manipulation combined with the use of individual micro-enterprises (**MEIs**) has become a recurring global vector for funneling illicit funds in cyber fraud. In this case, the victim (**M.C.B.**) made a wire transfer (**Pix**) of **R$ 1,600.00** after negotiating fake tickets with a seemingly female profile. This is a classic social engineering attack carried out via a rudimentary *sock puppet*.

The payment was *not sent to a natural person*, but to a *corporate* account linked to the **CNPJ** (National Registry of Legal Entities) **51.208.XXX/0001-XX**. The application of Open-Source Intelligence (**OSINT**) not only helped track down the perpetrators but also exposed blind spots in the initial customer verification (***onboarding***) processes of financial institutions. Often, negligence in these workflows creates strict and subjective liability for the bank or fintech—which acts as the expert in the ecosystem—rather than the end-user victimized by pure or hybrid social engineering (*such as malicious links or fake hotsites*).

Data Collection Phase The investigation began by mapping the digital footprint of the company's owner, strictly using open sources such as public records and open forums. (It is worth noting that advanced cross-referencing with data breaches and the use of **Google Dorks** can drastically enrich data collection *without the need to access illicit panels or the Deep Web*).

Queries to public databases revealed that the company was registered to **M.A.S.M.**. The official registry indicated **3 years** of activity, a declared share capital of **R$ 70,000.00**, and a primary business activity listed as "*Restaurants and similar establishments*". Additionally, the public record linked the **CNPJ** to the official corporate email: m**********8@gmail.com.

Information Processing and Analysis

With the registration email identified, the next step was to verify where else this credential had an active history—an analytical funnel process akin to moving data from a data lake to a data silo. Reverse-engineering the username revealed active registrations on e-commerce sites (such as Mercado Livre), tech forums, and video platforms. This highlights the reuse of the same digital identity across multiple online services. Fraudsters frequently leave these "footprints" due to amateurism or overconfidence. Furthermore, extracting the Google Account ID revealed public reviews left by the user on Google Maps. The reviewed locations were heavily concentrated in the South Zone of São Paulo, precisely matching the region of the physical CNPJ address registered with the Federal Revenue Service.

Where Security Checks Failed
The correlation of the extracted data points to clear traits of an account operated by a "*money mule*":

- The ***account holder*** had a commercial registry with a high share capital (**R$ 70,000.00**) that was entirely ***incompatible*** with their real *socioeconomic profile* and personal ***background***.
- The company, legally registered in the food service sector, was processing high-value transactions under the guise of entertainment ticket sales.

These discrepancies prove that the account validation was limited to a bureaucratic check of the CNPJ's "active" status, completely ignoring behavioral monitoring and consistency with the declared economic activity.

Conclusion Cyber *scams* thrive by exploiting superficial registry verifications. This case demonstrates how the practical application of **OSINT** techniques can reconstruct the money trail and identify critical operational flaws. To make anti-fraud prevention truly effective, institutional risk analysis workflows (such as **KYB** - Know Your Business) must go ***beyond basic document checking*** and continuously monitor the real routine and behavior of corporate accounts.

About the Author

André Almeida
Civil Police Investigator (**PCSP**) with *10 years of experience*, focusing on the investigation of criminal offenses, police intelligence, and Open-Source Intelligence (**OSINT**) techniques. He is a Law student at Universidade Cidade de São Paulo (**UNICID**) and holds a degree in Social Communication with a specialization in Advertising and Marketing (2009) from Universidade São Judas Tadeu (**USJT**).